the big moments but I really don't believe I'm someone who gets carried away with them. I didn't arrive at training expecting anyone to pat me on the back and say how well I'd played. It wasn't something for me to get big-headed about. I was just turning up to work at United in a very good mood. The boss obviously didn't see it like that. At least, he didn't see me like that. He thought what I needed was to be dumped back down to earth.

It must have been a strange season for the manager. Maybe he wished he hadn't had to tell anyone he was retiring. Like I've said, I don't think it affected the United players. If the boss was reading in the papers day after day that it did, though, perhaps he started to believe it himself. I don't know what made him change his mind. I just remember him telling us he had. It was early February 2002. We were in the dressing room at Carrington after training one morning.

'I'm staying on.'

It was as simple as that. I remember Gary Neville clapping and one or two of the other lads joking:

'Oh no, you're not are you?'

We were all really happy: me more than anybody, although, in hindsight, it probably meant the beginning of the end for me at the club. Back then, I didn't have any idea what was going to happen between me and the boss over the next seventeen months. I can still remember that lunchtime and the mix of relief and excitement that came with hearing that the only manager I'd ever worked for had decided to stay as boss of Manchester United. Alex Ferguson had been the making of me and the club. Why wouldn't I have been happy to know he was carrying on?

The manager's decision definitely gave us a lift and we had a good run in the second half of 2001/02. Not good enough to win the League, though: Arsenal were absolutely flying and won their last dozen games and the title. They won the FA Cup too: Middlesbrough and Steve McClaren, of all people, knocked us out in the fourth round. Our best chance was in Europe. We played Deportivo La Coruña in the first group phase and lost to them twice but, come the spring, we drew them in the quarter-finals and those previous results didn't mean a thing. We played them in Spain first and won 2–0. The team played so well, especially considering Roy Keane had to go off with a hamstring injury just before half-time. I scored one of my all-time favorite United goals that night. I got the ball, about thirty yards out, and whipped a shot in early. The goalie hadn't been expecting it: he was caught a little off his